ruary 2025 by the International Crops Research Institute for the Semi-Arid Tropics (ICRISAT), the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI), and the Center for Economic and Social Studies (CESS) across six states in India found that over 80 per cent of 785 households surveyed consume less protein than is recommended.

That's primarily because Indians get 60–75 per cent of their protein intake through cereals—largely from rice and wheat. However, cereals lack the amino acids required for the human body. "The digestibility quotient of the proteins from cereals is only 60 per cent. Hence, qualitative protein deficiency remains in many people even if they are consuming the right quantity," says Dr. B. Sesikeran, former director of ICMR-NIN. He suggests increasing the consumption of pulses as well as milk, curd, nuts, seeds and eggs that can provide all the essential amino acids.

Experts recommend a balanced diet providing quality protein without the need for supplements or processed options. For instance, one egg has 6 grams of protein, a 100 gram bowl of curd has 3-5 grams, and a 250 ml glass of milk provides 7-9 grams. But many leading a faster urban lifestyle find it difficult to eat the same food in larger quantities or repetitively. That's where the FMCG companies are coming together to fill this gap.

FORTIFYING YOUR SNACKS

For the conventional eater, there is ITC's high-protein aata, where three rotis claim to fulfil 25 per cent of daily protein needs. Similarly, brands like Amul, Parag Milk Foods and Milky Mist are pushing protein-fortified paneer, curd and cheese. Amul, India's iconic FMCG brand, has set itself the target of launching 12 high-protein products this year, ranging from paneer paranthas to protein water, high-protein aata and cola bars. With these additions, its protein portfolio will have a spread of 25 products by next year, says Jayen Mehta, managing director, Amul (Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation, or GCMMF).

Tamil Nadu-based dairy brand Milky Mist has introduced a high-protein paneer offering 50 grams of protein in a 200 g pack, along with Skyr Yogurt, an Icelandic staple, now providing 12 grams of protein per 100 gm serving in India. Other options include high-protein idli-dosa batter from Karnataka Milk Federation's Nandini and iD Fresh.

Indeed, among protein products, the largest growth is coming from dairy brands, which are driving mass adoption with affordable offerings starting at Rs 25 for curd, buttermilk and shakes. To meet rising demand, Amul doubled its production capacity of high-protein products last month and plans to double it again next month. Monthly sales have already quadrupled from last year. However, Mehta did not share revenue figures.

When it comes to business, snacking leads the way, followed by targeted protein products for women and seniors and then fortified traditional Indian foods (like millet laddus, idli and dosa batter etc.), says Adarsh Menon, partner at Fireside Ventures, a venture capital firm. 'Better-for-you' snacks are

ALL ABOUT PROTEIN

The nature of protein, what it does, its requirement in humans and if Indians get enough of it

What is protein?



It is a large biomolecule made up of chains of smaller amino acid molecules. Along with carbohydrates and fats, it is one of the three essential nutrients the body

What does it do?



- It is critical for the structure, function and regulation of tissues and organs
- It is the building block of cells and tissues, including muscle, bone, skin and hair
- It also fights viruses, breaks down nutrients in food, speeds up chemical reactions within cells, transports molecules (e.g. haemoglobin and some hormones)
- Protein deficiency causes muscle weakness, a weakened immune system and reduced energy

How much protein does one need?

- According to the Indian Council of Medical Research, a healthy adult person needs 0.83 gram of protein per kg of body weight every day
- Thus, an adult weighing 60 kg needs around 50 gm of protein daily



How much protein do Indians consume?

- The Household Consumption Expenditure Survey 2023-24 shows protein intake rose from 59.3 gm per person per day in FY10 to 61.8 gm in FY24 in rural India
- In urban India, it rose from 58.8 gm per person per day in FY10 to 63.4 gm in FY24
- In spite of this increase, a 2025 research in six states found over 80 per cent of 785 households surveyed had less protein than is needed
- This is because most Indians get 60-75 per cent of protein from rice and wheat, which lack essential amino acids